Chapter One

Redeeming the Republic

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Let me begin with two epiphanies.

A few years ago, I visited a book fair held on the seafront in Kochi. The local publishers were represented, as were Indian and foreign firms. In between the stall of Oxford University Press and a shop stocking the works in Malayalam translation of Marx, Engels and Lenin, I came across a man selling, of all things, pickles from Bikaner. He had placed his wares in large open buckets, one containing *aam ka murabba*, another *shalgam ka achar*. I asked the young man how he had come from a northern desert to participate in a book fair in this southern port. '*Maine suna ki Keral mein mela lag raha tha*,' he answered, '*aur maine socha ki wahan ek dukan khol doon*.' (I heard that there was some kind of fair on in Kerala, so I thought, why don't I bid for a stall there?) Thus spoke a pickle man in a salad-bowl nation, adding his charmingly naïve logic to an apparently illogical country.

Some months after this encounter, I was travelling by car from Patiala to Amritsar. It was a hot day, and the countryside was monotonous. I fell asleep, and woke when the car slowed down. We were now in the market town of Khanna. I scanned the buildings and their signs.

One, particularly, caught my attention: it read, 'Indian Bank, Khanna Branch, Head Office, Rajaji Salai, Chennai'. I was charmed and uplifted, sentiments that (especially for the young) perhaps need explaining. For, 'Rajaji' was C. Rajagopalachari, the scholar–statesman who had been